

agree. "Everybody used to believe that you had to have West African genes or come from the Caribbean to be a world-class sprinter. Obviously, the last decade has shown us that's not necessarily true. We had, in Usain Bolt, an athlete who, according to conventional wisdom, had the wrong shape to be a sprinter (Bolt was far taller than most of his compatriots). We had a Chinese sprinter in the 100m finals in Tokyo. The Chinese 4x100m team also won an Olympic medal in Tokyo. I think people are starting to realise that the genetic argument only goes so far in explaining sprint success," says Christopher Pedra, who has worked for several years in India as a sports scientist.

Pedra notes that Indians don't even have to look as far as China for inspiration to dismiss the genetic excuse. Just a couple of years ago, Sri Lanka's Yupun Abeykoon clocked a time of 9.96 seconds, becoming the first South Asian to break the 10-second barrier in the 100m — considered one of the gold standards of track excellence.

So why haven't Indians come anywhere near that mark? And just what will it take for the first Indian to breach that barrier?

According to Gurindervir Singh, who himself clocked 10.27 seconds in 2021 — the fifth-fastest time ever recorded by an Indian — the problem starts with a lack of self-belief. "No one really believes that Indians can be good sprinters, not even our coaches. I started my athletics career when I was in Class 7. At that time, I was inspired by Usain Bolt. But so many coaches told me that Indians can't do well in the 100m. They told me that if I wanted to make a career for myself, I should shift to the 400m. We had many Asian Games medals in the 400m but none in the 100m. But I always wanted to change that mentality," says the 24-year-old.

While Gurindervir says he was always adamant about being a sprinter, he admits that things didn't get much easier for him. His personal best came three years ago, but since then he has faced two

years of recurring injuries. He has only recently started putting together some consistent performances, clocking a time of 10.32 seconds at the National Championships in June this year.

Some of this is inevitable. "The sprint is just violence. The faster you have to run, the more force your body has to generate. And the more

force you have to generate, the more force your body has to tolerate. If you are talking about running a 10-second 100m, you are talking about the fastest people in the world. So, you've got these people producing the most amount of force, probably more than any other athlete in the world. As they hit the ground, they have to generate force



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